



MEONCROSS SCHOOL | HISTORY DEPARTMENT

EDITION 2026.1

HOW DID DECADES OF IMPERIAL RIVALRY AND FEAR CULMINATE IN THIRTY DAYS OF MADNESS?

KS3: Causes of the Great War

Scholar: _____

Class: _____

PROGRESS & ASSESSMENT TRACKER

TARGET GRADE: _____

Level	Emerging (1-2)	Emerging+ (3)	Expected (4-5)	Expected+ (6-7) / Greater Depth (8-9)
Lesson / Assessment Title	Effort	Level	Teacher Comments	
L1: How was the German Empire created in 1871?				
L2: How did the Franco-Prussian War create a lasting legacy of hatred?				
L3: To what extent did the 'Scramble for Africa' increase tension in Europe?				
L4: Why did a battleship building contest destroy Anglo-German relations?				
L5: Did the Alliance System protect Europe or guarantee a global war?				
L6: Why did a single assassination in Sarajevo ignite a World War?				
Assessment: End of Unit Assessment: The Historians' Debate				
Final Unit Grade:				

L1: How was the German Empire created in 1871?

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- ☐ Understand how Otto von Bismarck used 'blood and iron' to unify the German states.
- ☐ Analyze the geographical impact of the new German Empire on the balance of power in Europe.

Q1. Look at the A4 map provided. Why might the geographical location of the new German Empire cause fear for both Germany and its neighbors?

Vocabulary Check

The Odd One Out: Select *THREE* terms that share a close historical connection. Identify which *ONE* remaining term is the 'Odd One Out' in this lesson, and explain your historical reasoning:

Unification | Prussia | Chancellor | Blood and Iron | Realpolitik | Kaiser

Q2. Interpreting 'Blood and Iron'. In your own words, explain what Otto von Bismarck meant when he said Germany would be united by 'blood and iron'. How did Prussia use its industrial and military power to prove Bismarck's speech right between 1864 and 1871?

Q3. The Steps to Unification. Create a three-step staircase diagram in your book to show how Bismarck built the German Empire. For each step, write down: 1. The name of the country Prussia defeated. 2. The year of the war. 3. How this war helped Prussia achieve its ultimate goal of unification.

Assessment Practice: Explanatory Causation Paragraph

Pair & Share Activity

Q4. Prompt: Discuss with your partner: Was the German Empire created 'from below' by the people or 'from above' by military force?

Think: Spend 1 minute quietly considering the question and forming your own opinion.

Your Notes:

Q5. Explain why Otto von Bismarck's policy of 'Blood and Iron' was successful in unifying Germany by 1871.

[12 marks • 15 mins]

Scaffolding & Hints:

- Point 1: Rejection of Liberalism — Bismarck bypassed parliament and funded the army unilaterally to prioritize military force over democratic debate.
- Point 2: Industrial & Military Modernisation — Prussian railways for rapid mobilization and Krupp steel breach-loading artillery.
- Point 3: Three Decisive Wars (1864, 1866, 1870) — Defeating Denmark, excluding Austria, and uniting southern German states against a common French enemy.
- Point 4: Crowned at Versailles — Proclamation of the Kaiserreich on 18 January 1871, permanently shifting the European balance of power.

General Notes

- ☐ Emerging (1-2) ☐ Emerging+ (3) ☐ Expected (4-5) ☐ Expected+ (6-7) ☐ Greater Depth (8-9)

Teacher Comment:

L2: How did the Franco-Prussian War create a lasting legacy of hatred?

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- ☐ Identify the penalties forced upon France in 1871.
- ☐ Explain how the Ems Telegram sparked the Franco-Prussian War.
- ☐ Evaluate the long-term impact on European relations.

Q1. What are the two opposing figures doing in this 1871 painting by Anton von Werner, and why is this event significant?

Chronological Domino Flowchart

Score: / 5

Task: The historical events below are out of order. Read them carefully, then use your pen to **draw arrows connecting the boxes** in the correct chronological and causal order (Event A → Event B → Event C...).



1. Looking at this long-term timeline, which factor do you think was the most dangerous necessary cause of the war?

Vocabulary Check

The Golden Sentence: Choose TWO terms from the word bank. Write ONE grammatically sophisticated, historically accurate sentence connecting them using a causal conjunction (because, although, or consequently):

Ems Telegram | Siege | Reparations | Alsace-Lorraine | Revanchism | Treaty of Frankfurt

Q2. Explain how Bismarck used the Ems Telegram and Prussia's military advantages (railways and Krupp artillery) to provoke and rapidly defeat France in 1870–71.

Q3. Explain the three severe penalties forced upon France in 1871 and why crowning the Kaiser inside the Palace of Versailles created a lasting legacy of hatred.

Historian's Corner: The 'Master Planner' Debate

Historians debate whether Bismarck was a genius 'master planner' who plotted the Franco-Prussian War years in advance, or merely a brilliant opportunist who reacted to events (like the Ems Telegram) as they happened. A.J.P. Taylor famously argued Bismarck just rode the wave of events.

Q4. How does A.J.P. Taylor's view of Bismarck as an 'opportunist' challenge the traditional narrative that the Franco-Prussian War was meticulously planned?

Writing Practice

Pair & Share Activity

Q5. Prompt: Of the three penalties forced upon France in the 1871 treaty (loss of land, 5 billion franc fine, German occupation), which do you think caused the most bitter resentment, and why?

Think: Jot down your choice and one strong reason to support it.

Your Notes:

Q6. How useful are Sources A and B for an enquiry into the reasons for French hatred of Germany after 1871?

[8 marks • 10 mins]

Source A

Adapted from a French school textbook, published in Paris, 1885.

“We must never forget the humiliation of 1871. The German Empire was proclaimed in our own Palace of Versailles, tearing away the bleeding wounds of Alsace and Lorraine. They have stolen our iron and our factories, and forced us to pay a crushing ransom of 5 billion francs. Every French child must grow up with one single thought: to rebuild our army and take back what was stolen from the motherland.”

Source B

Adapted from a private letter written by German Chancellor Otto von Bismarck to a fellow diplomat, 1872.

“France will never forgive us for taking Alsace-Lorraine. The peace we have forced upon them has left a bitter resentment that will not fade. We must accept that a French war of revenge is a certainty in the future. Therefore, our entire diplomatic focus must be to ensure she never finds an ally to help her take it back. As long as France remains diplomatically isolated, particularly from Russia, Germany will remain secure.”

General Notes

- ☐ Emerging (1-2) ☐ Emerging+ (3) ☐ Expected (4-5) ☐ Expected+ (6-7) ☐ Greater Depth (8-9)

Teacher Comment:

L3: To what extent did the 'Scramble for Africa' increase tension in Europe?

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- ☐ Identify the main European colonial powers and their territories.
- ☐ Explain how Kaiser Wilhelm II's 'Place in the Sun' policy threatened Britain.
- ☐ Evaluate the impact of the Moroccan Crises on the Entente Cordiale.

Q1. Look closely at the man standing over Africa. What is his posture suggesting about imperial ambitions?

Do Now Activity

Score: / 10

1. Who was the first Emperor of the newly unified Germany in 1871?

2. Which brilliant Chancellor united the German states?

3. Which country was humiliatingly defeated in the Franco-Prussian War?

4. What strategic border territory did Germany take in 1871?

5. What is the French word for their desire for revenge?

6. Explain how Bismarck used the Ems Telegram to trap France into a war.

7. Detail the two military advantages the Prussian army possessed.

8. Why was the location of the German Empire's proclamation so humiliating for France?

9. Why did Bismarck weave a complex web of secret alliances after 1871?

10. What was Bismarck's ultimate nightmare scenario?

Vocabulary Check

Conceptual Classification: Categorise the terms from the word bank into the two historical boxes below:

Imperialism | Scramble for Africa | Raw Materials | Berlin Conference | Empire | Colony

Power, Governance & Warfare

Economy, Trade & Society

Q2. Explain two distinct economic reasons why possessing overseas colonies was vital to the industrial growth of a Great Power.

Q3. Why did French politicians feel it was absolutely vital to maintain a firm hold on their remaining global colonies after 1871?

Q4. Explain how Germany's sudden desire to build a naval fleet to protect its new colonies acted as a cause of friction with Great Britain.

Q5. What specific geographical territory did Foreign Secretary Bernhard von Bülow target when he demanded a "place in the sun" for Germany?

Historian's Corner: The Primat der Innenpolitik

Some historians (like Eckart Kehr) argue that Wilhelm II's aggressive Weltpolitik was actually driven by domestic politics. By creating foreign enemies, the Kaiser hoped to distract the German working class from voting for socialist parties at home.

Q6. Explain how Eckart Kehr's theory connects Germany's aggressive foreign policy to its internal fears of a socialist revolution.

Assessment Practice: Narrative Account (8 Marks - Chronology & Causation)

Pair & Share Activity

Q7. Prompt: If you were a British politician in 1897, would you view Kaiser Wilhelm's 'Place in the Sun' speech as a direct threat, or just a young leader showing off? Why?

Think: Jot down your view and one piece of evidence.

Your Notes:

Q8. Write a narrative account analysing how the Moroccan Crises (1905 and 1911) led to rising tension between Germany, France, and Britain. You may use the following in your answer: • The Kaiser's visit to Tangier and the Algeiras Conference (1905-06) • The Panther at Agadir and British military preparations (1911) You must also use information of your own.

Scaffolding & Hints:

- Paragraph 1 (The Trigger - 1905): Kaiser Wilhelm II visits Tangier to test the Entente Cordiale and challenge French dominance.
- Paragraph 2 (The Diplomatic Backfire - 1906): The Algeiras Conference where Britain and Russia firmly back France, isolating Germany.
- Paragraph 3 (The Escalation - 1911): The Agadir Crisis, sending SMS Panther, Lloyd George's Mansion House speech, and joint Anglo-French naval planning.
- Causal Connectors: Ensure each paragraph explicitly links to the next using "This directly led to...", "As a consequence...", "This culminated in..."

General Notes

- ☐ Emerging (1-2) ☐ Emerging+ (3) ☐ Expected (4-5) ☐ Expected+ (6-7) ☐ Greater Depth (8-9)

Teacher Comment:

L4: Why did a battleship building contest destroy Anglo-German relations?

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- ☐ Identify the significance of the HMS Dreadnought.
- ☐ Explain the concept of the Two-Power Standard and Risk Theory.
- ☐ Analyze how naval competition fed mutual suspicion.

Q1. This blueprint represents the HMS Dreadnought. Why would this ship make all other navies obsolete?

Do Now Activity

Score: / 10

1. What was the name of Kaiser Wilhelm II's aggressive foreign policy?

2. Explain how Wilhelm II's actions during the Moroccan Crises backfired on Germany.

3. Why was the Franco-Russian Alliance a strategic disaster for Germany?

4. Evaluate how the 'Scramble for Africa' increased tensions in Europe.

5. Describe the impact of Britain abandoning its policy of 'Splendid Isolation'.

6. Evaluate the role of Wilhelm II's personality in destabilizing Europe.

7. Who dismissed Otto von Bismarck in 1890?

8. What strategic territory did Germany take from France in 1871?

9. Why did Bismarck weave a complex web of secret alliances after 1871?

10. What was Bismarck's ultimate nightmare scenario?

Vocabulary Check

Spot the Deliberate Error: Read the statement below. One historical fact or vocabulary concept has been deliberately falsified. Underline the error and explain the accurate historical reality below:

Naval Supremacy | Two-Power Standard | Militarism | Tirpitz Plan | Arms Race | Dreadnought

"In 1906, Britain abandoned its Two-Power Standard and conceded Naval Supremacy to Germany because the Tirpitz Plan made the Royal Navy dismantle all HMS Dreadnought battleships."

Q2. Describe the 'Two-Power Standard' and explain why Great Britain adhered to this strict naval policy.

Q3. Detail what the German Navy Laws of 1898 and 1900 explicitly ordered the German industrial shipyards to construct.

Q4. Explain how Admiral Tirpitz used the Navy League to manufacture civilian support and patriotism for Germany's expanding fleet.

Q5. Explain why maintaining a massive navy was a matter of survival for Great Britain, but was viewed as a matter of status and power for Germany.

Q6. Identify three specific technological features of HMS Dreadnought that made it superior to all previous warships, explaining why it reset the arms race.

Historian's Corner: The Anglo-German Antagonism

Paul Kennedy argues that the naval arms race was the single most decisive factor in turning Britain from a neutral observer into Germany's enemy, as the threat of a German navy fundamentally challenged Britain's core survival strategy.

Q7. Evaluate Paul Kennedy's argument. Why would Britain view a German naval buildup as a greater existential threat than a larger German army?

Assessment Practice: Historical Interpretation (Historians' Debate)

Pair & Share Activity

Q8. Prompt: Who do you think was more to blame for the naval arms race: Germany for building a fleet they didn't strictly need, or Britain for refusing to share control of the seas?

Think: Decide who is more to blame and write down your main reason.

Your Notes:

Q9. Historian Paul Kennedy argues that the Anglo-German naval arms race was "the single most decisive factor" that turned Britain from a neutral observer into Germany's determined enemy. How far do you agree with this interpretation of the causes of Anglo-German hostility? Explain your answer using your own knowledge and evaluating both sides of the debate.

Scaffolding & Hints:

- Point 1 (Supporting Kennedy): Maritime Island Security — Britain depended entirely on merchant lifelines; Tirpitz's High Seas Fleet and the 1900 Navy Laws directly challenged the Two-Power Standard and threatened starvation.
- Point 2 (Supporting Kennedy): The Dreadnought Reset & Public Panic — The 1906 Dreadnought reset the race, prompting intense British jingoism, press hysteria, and the 1909 popular campaign ("We want eight, and we won't wait!").
- Point 3 (Challenging Kennedy): Imperial Provocation — Tensions were already inflamed by Weltpolitik outside Europe: the Kruger Telegram (1896), the Boer War, and German bullying in Morocco (Tangier 1905, Agadir 1911).
- Point 4 (Alternative Factor): Continental Neutrality & Belgium — By 1912, Britain had decisive numerical victory in the naval race (29 Dreadnoughts to 17); what ultimately triggered war was Germany's violation of Belgian neutrality under the 1839 Treaty of London.

General Notes

- ☐ Emerging (1-2) ☐ Emerging+ (3) ☐ Expected (4-5) ☐ Expected+ (6-7) ☐ Greater Depth (8-9)

Teacher Comment:

L5: Did the Alliance System protect Europe or guarantee a global war?

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- ☐ Identify the members of the Triple Alliance and the Triple Entente.
- ☐ Explain why countries felt the need to form secret defensive treaties.
- ☐ Evaluate how the alliance system could drag all of Europe into a regional conflict.

Q1. Study the intertwined hands and figures in this cartoon. What does it suggest about how a local conflict might spread?

Do Now Activity

Score: / 10

1. What revolutionary British battleship was launched in 1906?

2. What was the 'Two-Power Standard'?

3. Why did Germany feel it needed a massive high seas fleet?

4. Explain how the invention of the Dreadnought ironically hurt British supremacy.

5. What was the popular British slogan chanted by the public in 1909?

6. Why did Britain feel their survival depended on massive naval supremacy?

7. How did the Anglo-German naval race make war more likely?

8. What was the name of Kaiser Wilhelm II's aggressive foreign policy?

9. Explain how Wilhelm II's actions during the Moroccan Crises backfired on Germany.

10. Evaluate how the 'Scramble for Africa' increased tensions in Europe.

Vocabulary Check

The Odd One Out: Select *THREE* terms that share a close historical connection. Identify which *ONE* remaining term is the 'Odd One Out' in this lesson, and explain your historical reasoning:

Dual Alliance | Reinsurance Treaty | Triple Alliance | Splendid Isolation | Triple Entente | Encirclement

Q2 Enquiry: Look at the geographical position of Germany and Austria-Hungary. Why would they feel encircled by the Triple Entente? [p. 24]

Q3. Identify the specific member countries that made up the Triple Alliance and the Triple Entente by 1907.

Q4. Explain the diplomatic logic of how the alliance system was theoretically supposed to keep European nations safe from a outbreak of war.

Q5. According to Germany's military leaders, explain why a European war was considered "inevitable and necessary" rather than avoidable.

Q6. Detail how the massive expansion of steel production and railway tracks across Europe altered the speed and scale of army mobilization.

Historian's Corner: The 'Powder Keg' Inevitability

Was war inevitable in the Balkans? Richard Evans argues that the complex alliance system turned the Balkans into a doomsday machine, where any small conflict was mathematically guaranteed to drag all the Great Powers into a general war.

Q7. Do you agree with Richard Evans that war was "inevitable" in the Balkans, or could diplomacy have dismantled the "doomsday machine"?

Assessment Practice: Multi-Causation Essay (16 Marks)

Pair & Share Activity

Q8. Prompt: Imagine you are an ordinary Serbian citizen in 1908. Why would Austria-Hungary's aggressive takeover of Bosnia make you feel personally threatened?

Think: Write down how you would feel and why.

Your Notes:

Q9. "The alliance system was the primary reason why a European war broke out in 1914." How far do you agree with this statement? Explain your answer.

[16 marks • 20 mins]

Scaffolding & Hints:

- Factor 1 (Agreed): The rigid domino effect of the Triple Alliance and Triple Entente mutual defence treaties, which ensured a regional Balkan dispute escalated uncontrollably into a general European conflict.
- Factor 2 (Agreed): German paranoia regarding "encirclement" and the rigid requirements of the Schlieffen Plan, meaning German railway mobilization was legally equivalent to an act of war.
- Factor 3 (Alternative): German aggressive militarism and the unconditional "Blank Cheque" (5 July 1914) that gave Austria-Hungary the confidence to declare war on Serbia.
- Factor 4 (Alternative / Counter): Long-term imperial rivalries and the Anglo-German naval arms race that had already poisoned European relations and created two irreconcilable armed camps.

General Notes

☐ Emerging (1-2) ☐ Emerging+ (3) ☐ Expected (4-5) ☐ Expected+ (6-7) ☐ Greater Depth (8-9)

Teacher Comment:

L6: Why did a single assassination in Sarajevo ignite a World War?

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- ☐ Identify the events of 28 June 1914.
- ☐ Explain how the assassination triggered the alliance system.
- ☐ Analyze whether the resulting war was inevitable or accidental.

Q1. Look at the men sitting on the 'Balkan Troubles' pot. What are they desperately trying to prevent?

Do Now Activity

Score: / 10

1. Which three countries made up the Triple Entente?

2. Which three countries made up the Triple Alliance?

3. Explain the theoretical logic of how the alliance system was supposed to keep peace.

4. Why did the alliance system actually increase paranoia instead of security?

5. What military plan did Germany create to avoid a long two-front war?

6. Which neutral country did the Schlieffen Plan require invading?

7. What feeling of being surrounded by enemies haunted German planners?

8. What revolutionary British battleship was launched in 1906?

9. Explain how the invention of the Dreadnought ironically hurt British supremacy.

10. How did the Anglo-German naval race make war more likely?

Vocabulary Check

The Golden Sentence: Choose TWO terms from the word bank. Write ONE grammatically sophisticated, historically accurate sentence connecting them using a causal conjunction (because, although, or consequently):

Nationalism | Assassination | Black Hand | Blank Cheque | Ultimatum | Mobilisation

Q2. Explain why the rise of independent Balkan states and Pan-Slavic nationalism represented an existential threat to the Austro-Hungarian Empire.

Q3. Detail how the initial failure of the bomb plot inadvertently placed Archduke Franz Ferdinand directly in front of Gavrilo Princip.

Q4. Outline the chronological sequence of events from July 23 to August 4, 1914, that transformed a local Balkan assassination into a total European war.

Q5. What does the desperate tone of the 'Willy-Nicky Telegrams' reveal about the monarchs' control over the escalating July Crisis?

Q6. Explain why the First World War rapidly expanded into a global conflict rather than remaining a strictly European war.

Historian's Corner: The Fischer Controversy

In 1961, German historian Fritz Fischer shocked the world by arguing that Germany deliberately caused WWI to achieve world power status. He pointed to the 'Blank Cheque' as evidence that Germany actively pushed Austria into war, knowing it would provoke Russia.

Q7. How does the 'Blank Cheque' support Fritz Fischer's controversial claim that Germany actively sought a wider war?

Assessment Practice: Explaining Causation & The Spark (12 Marks)

Pair & Share Activity

Q8. Prompt: Look at the timeline of the July Crisis. At which exact moment do you think a world war became completely unstoppable? Was it the assassination, the blank cheque, or the mobilisations?

Think: Pick the specific turning point and write down why you chose it.

Your Notes:

Q9. Explain why the assassination of Archduke Franz Ferdinand in Sarajevo led to the outbreak of the First World War in August 1914.

[12 marks • 15 mins]

Scaffolding & Hints:

- Point 1: The assassination on 28 June 1914 provided the Austro-Hungarian military with a long-desired pretext to crush Serbian nationalism once and for all.
- Point 2: The German "Blank Cheque" (5 July) provided unconditional backing, emboldening Austria-Hungary to issue an impossibly harsh 48-hour ultimatum to Serbia.
- Point 3: The Russian decision to order general mobilisation to protect its Slavic ally Serbia activated the reciprocal alliances of the Triple Entente.
- Point 4: The rigidity of the German Schlieffen Plan required an immediate pre-emptive invasion through neutral Belgium, compelling Great Britain to enter the war.

General Notes

- ☐ Emerging (1-2) ☐ Emerging+ (3) ☐ Expected (4-5) ☐ Expected+ (6-7) ☐ Greater Depth (8-9)

Teacher Comment:

End of Unit Assessment: The Historians' Debate

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- ☐ Identify the core difference in argument between Interpretation 1 and Interpretation 2 regarding war guilt.
- ☐ Explain why two historians might reach differing conclusions using primary source evidence (Sources B and C).
- ☐ Write a balanced, 16-mark essay evaluating how far they agree with the Fischer thesis using contextual knowledge.

Vocabulary Check

Conceptual Classification: Categorise the terms from the word bank into the two historical boxes below:

Militarism Alliances Imperialism Nationalism Short-War Illusion War Guilt	
Power, Governance & Warfare	Economy, Trade & Society

Writing Practice

Exam Sources & Interpretations

Interpretation 1: Christopher Clark, 'The Sleepwalkers' (2012)

No single nation can be entirely blamed for starting the First World War. The spark was the tragic assassination in Sarajevo, but the real problem was the rigid system of alliances. When the crisis erupted, leaders across all major powers blundered into a war they did not want, dragged along by secret treaties and the fear of being attacked first. The protagonists of 1914 were sleepwalkers, watchful but unseeing, blind to the reality of the horror they were about to bring into the world.

Interpretation 2: Fritz Fischer, 'Germany's Aims in the First World War' (1961)

The outbreak of the First World War was entirely the fault of Germany's aggressive militarism. The German leadership deliberately encouraged Austria to attack Serbia, giving them a "blank cheque" of support. Germany used the assassination in Sarajevo as a convenient excuse to launch a massive war and conquer Europe. The German military elite deliberately risked a continental war in 1914 in order to break their encirclement and achieve world power status before Russia became too strong.

Q1. 1. What is the main difference between Interpretation 1 and Interpretation 2 regarding who was to blame for the war?

[4 marks • 5 mins]

Q2. 2. Suggest one reason why Interpretation 1 and Interpretation 2 give different views. You may use Sources B and C to help explain your answer.

[4 marks • 5 mins]

TEACHER FEEDBACK / D.I.R.T.

Q3. 3. How far do you agree with Interpretation 2 about the causes of the Great War?

[16 marks • 20 mins]

General Notes

- ☐ Emerging (1-2) ☐ Emerging+ (3) ☐ Expected (4-5) ☐ Expected+ (6-7) ☐ Greater Depth (8-9)

Teacher Comment:

End of Unit Reflection & Pupil Voice

Unit: Causes of the Great War (1870–1914)

Instructions: Now that you have completed your final assessment, take 10 minutes to reflect on your learning across this entire unit. Be honest—this is your chance to use your **Pupil Voice** to help your teacher plan future lessons.

1. What Went Well (WWW)

What topic or skill did you find most engaging or easiest to understand in this unit?

2. Even Better If (EBI)

What did you find most challenging? Are there any concepts you are still confused about?

3. Effort & Target Setting

Circle your effort level for this unit: **1 (Low)** **2** **3** **4** **5 (Excellent)**

What is one specific target you want to set for yourself in the next unit?

Teacher Feedback & Coaching

(To be completed during live marking / feedback lessons)